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Panasonic Lumix G100 Launch

The mirrorless vlogger oriented camera features high sound quality produced by Nokia's OZO Audio. <http://digit.in/jan21-44>

Amazon Echo Dot 4th Gen

Compact and bassless

The Amazon Echo Dot 4th Gen arrives with a visual makeover to raise the benchmark set by the older Echo Dot speakers. It undoubtedly brings several changes over the 3rd Gen Echo Dot but also costs slightly higher, at ₹4,499. Amazon has moved on from the hockey puck-like shape to a spherical shape, that resembles a bonsai version of the bigger Echo 4th Gen.



Price
₹4,499

4th Gen offers better-defined audio, whereas its competitor is a bit on the softer side. None of these speakers is good enough to crack a party, but if you care about the details more than loudness, the Echo Dot 4th Gen should be your pick.

If you wish to use your smart speaker as a go-to music player, you can pair two 4th Gen Dot speakers to get stereo sound, but we would recommend going for a Google Nest Audio or the 4th Gen Echo instead. If you've heard the previous Echo Dot speakers and find them suitable for your use, the 4th Gen is good enough for all use cases.

Design and build

The Echo Dot 4th Gen has morphed itself from a boring hockey-puck like shape to a bigger and not-so-discrete spheroidal form. Pulling it out of the box for the first time was quite refreshing as even though we saw it in pictures, we still weren't sure of its size. The palm-sized speaker comes in black, white and blue (the one we received) colours.

As we mentioned, the design is refreshing, but it does remind you of the last-gen Dot as it uses the same muted mesh-covered design, albeit in a different geometrical profile as a welcome change. Yet, it's worth noting that Amazon has kept the footprint the same as the older generation Dot speakers. Which means that despite a taller design, it will not take up more shelf space. Do note that it's not as easy to mount on a wall like the previous design. The ball-shaped speaker is covered with fabric mesh at the top, split diagonally where the bottom half is made of plastic and has a flat rubberized base. Unlike the previous models, Amazon Echo's signature ring light surrounds the base. It illuminates in red, yellow and blue like other Echo speakers.

The four constant buttons of the Echo Dot - volume up/down, micro-



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phone on/off, and a button to wake Alexa - are placed right on the top. The connections are located at the back and the 3.5 mm jack can be used to connect an external speaker, but sadly it does not double as a line-in.

Audio quality

After the design, the other major upgrade is in the audio performance. It has a more powerful 1.6-inch speaker; larger than the 3rd Gen's 1.1-inch speaker, and slightly more powerful than the 1.5-inch Nest Mini. Even during tests, the new Echo Dot sounded more powerful and fuller than the other two.

You will enjoy the audio unless you demand heavy bass from it. It is fairly loud and has sharp mids for great vocals and speech, but the lack of bass might upset R'n'B or trap fans. Its round shape might get you thinking it offers directional sound, but it's uni-directional, and even the soundstage is somewhat shallow.

The audio is much louder than the previous generation Dot, but it does face some competition from the Mi Smart Speaker. At the same price, the Mi Smart Speaker has a larger, more accommodating 2.5-inch, 12W full-range driver to beat the Echo Dot in loudness and bass. The Echo Dot

Microphone performance and voice response

When we reviewed the Google Nest Audio, we found its microphone performance to be more impressive than the audio performance. It turns out the Echo Dot 4th Gen nails it too. In more than a month of usage, we don't remember when was the last time the new Dot disappointed at picking up voice commands. The mics are sensitive, and the AZ1 Neural Edge processor does an excellent job at recognition and response. You only need to raise your voice if it's playing a song at volume level eight or above, and you are more than 10 feet away from it.

Verdict

The Echo Dot 4th Gen is a great smart speaker but despite a refreshing design and louder audio, it seems non-essential if you want to get the best value for money entry-level smart speaker. The Echo 3rd Gen is still a better deal with slightly inferior audio performance.

—Sudhanshu Singh

SPECIFICATIONS

BLUETOOTH: With A2DP | PORTS: 3.5mm audio output | SPEAKER: 1.6-inch speaker | WI-FI: Dual-band 802.11ac | Size: 100 x 100 x 89 mm | WEIGHT: 341.3g

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